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Journal:	*Online Information Review*
Manuscript ID	OIR-03-2022-0161.R1
Manuscript Type:	Research Paper
Keywords:	Twitter, Cyprus problem, Public Sphere, intergroup vicarious and parasocial contact, intergroup relational identity

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Tweet for Peace: Twitter as a medium for developing a peace discourse in the hands of the Greek-Cypriot and Turkish-Cypriot leaders

Abstract

Purpose- The article examines how the two Cypriot leaders – the Greek-Cypriot community leader Nicos Anastasiades and the Turkish-Cypriot community leader Mustafa Akinci –have used their Twitter accounts during the period leading to the intensification of the Cyprus peace process between 30 April 2015– 30 November 2016.

Design/Methodology/Approach- This article presents using descriptive analysis and thematic analysis how the two leaders have used Twitter in the negotiations' period.

Findings- The analysis shows that the leaders during the timeframe examined, developed both pro-peace discourses around the Cyprus problem as well as parasocial and vicarious intergroup contact that contributed in what Hogg (2015) defines an intergroup relational identity that is an effective form of "bridging" leadership across communities.

Originality/Value- The article argues that Twitter is a tool that in the hands of political leaders in segregated public spheres caused by yet unresolved ethnic conflicts, can become a useful tool for constructing both a positive meaning around issues concerning the rival sides as well as a tool for transforming opposing social identities in the formation of an "extended sense of self that includes the collaboration partner" (Hogg 2015, p.191).

Introduction

The media's approach when framing news about the rival side in conflict-affected societies, becomes more negative when the peace process is in crisis. On the contrary, sharing media news across the conflicting lines can be beneficial to the process itself (Wolfsfeld, 2004) provided it resembles the conditions for beneficial intergroup contact set down by Allport (1954). The first, antagonistic framing, seems easier to achieve in places where sharing news about the peace process is being done separately and completely isolated for each conflicting side. This is the case in Cyprus, where the public sphere is segregated due to the different

Online Information Review

languages used by the media in the Greek-Cypriot (GC) and Turkish-Cypriot (TC) communities and most importantly due to the fact that the two communities live separated for more than 40 years now. During this period of separation, the information about the ongoing peace process for finding a solution to the Cyprus problem as well as the intergroup contact relied heavily on the media that process information separately in the two communities. A way to overcome this segregation and to provide a more open platform for civic participation is by using a tool for information sharing that both transcends physical separation and creates a common ground of communication. Social media are undoubtedly tools that have both the aforementioned characteristics and whenever they are used for purposes of contact between the two communities in Cyprus a more inclusive form of public sphere is developed (Karayianni, 2013).

This article explores the way information about the peace process are shared by the political protagonists of the process themselves, i.e. the two community leaders in Cyprus the GC leader N. Anastasiades and the TC leader M. Akinci, through their use of their Twitter accounts. The tweets published by the Cypriot leaders from the election of Mr. Akinci in 2015 until end of October 2016 just before the first Conference on Cyprus held in Mont Pelerin, are gathered and analysed aiming to understand how this new form of political diplomacy developed on Twitter could contribute to the development of intergroup contact that create a conducive environment for the Cyprus peace process.

This research is relevant to the new directions of journalism, communication and intergroup contact theory in several different ways. First, the fact that many media organisations are forced to shut down or at least proceed in decreasing the number of their employees due to the difficult financial situation in which Cyprus is during the last few years as well as the social restrictions that the pandemic imposed, make Twitter as even a more significant tool for both information source and production. Second, the use of social media for sharing news stories related to the peace process and/or the other community the time they happen, provides the only platform for

Online Information Review

the formation of a public sphere which is inclusive to both communities in Cyprus. Finally, the way the two community leaders, choose to share information on these matters, i.e. their choice of words and the thematic emphasis they give each time they tweet as well as the very act of sharing their in-between contact or addressing the other community directly through their tweets constitutes examples of parasocial intergroup contact that aims in developing what Hogg calls an intergroup relational identity (2015, p.190). Vicarious contact emerges when one sees an ingroup member interacting with an outgroup member while parasocial contact is achieved when ingroup members connect with outgroup members through mediated contact (Banas, Bessarabova & Massey, 2020).

This article examines *(RQ1)* how the two Cypriot community leaders, shared information and constructed meaning around the Cyprus problem on Twitter and *(RQ2)* how their tweeting activity achieved parasocial and vicarious intergroup contact tweeting that developed an intergroup relational identity for the Cypriots, an identity that could affect positively the peace process.

Twitter and politics

According to Twiplomacy 2020, "the governments of only four countries do not have a Twitter presence, namely Laos, North Korea, Sao Tome and Principe and Turkmenistan" (*Twiplomacy*, 2020). After the departure of Barak Obama, Donald Trump is still the most followed world leader with 81 million followers, followed by Indian Prime-Minister Narendra Modi with 57.9 million followers and Pope Francis with 51.2 million followers.

It seems that world's leaders understand the power that Twitter has given them as a channel of communication with the public. As Broersma and Graham place it "tweeting offers politicians the opportunity for a virtual handshake and direct conversation with voters" (2015, p.96).

Online Information Review

Scholars, who have recognised the political use of Twitter, have examined the links between the leaders' or politicians' twitter activity with their political power. Gainous and Wagner (2014) examined of the way social media's use by candidates generated votes in US elections to argue that this can make them win or lose elections. They also suggest that the new interactions among people and new relationships that are developed online affect political engagement and participation (Gainous and Wagner, 2014). Furthermore, the political use of Twitter has expanded the "hybrid ways in which politics is now mediated" (Chadwick, 2013, p.102), meaning that the political information cycle is now more unpredictable as it depends on both elite and non-elite actors who are both involved in the news production process (Chadwick, 2013).

Researchers who examine the phenomenon of Twiplomacy however, are constantly questioning as Sykes successfully puts it: "what comes first, the power or the tweet?" (2013, p.3). These studies usually compare the communication practices followed by political actors both offline and online and most of them conclude that the political actors that dominate the offline political discourse tend to do so in the social media context too (Jürgens & Jungherr, 2011, Jungherr & Jürgens 2014; Klinger, 2013). Research has identified exceptions too however, like the Green Party in Switzerland that dominated the political discussion on Twitter until 2009 (Rauchfleisch & Metag, 2016) or the Pirate party in Germany which dominated the online political discussion even before winning any parliament seats (Jungherr, 2014).

Bjola et. al. (2019), in his seminal work on digital diplomacy highlights the significance of the use of digital technology in public diplomacy. As he places it:

> By going "digital," the once secretive and exclusive domain of the elite has also gone public, requiring diplomats to regularly look outside their once closed doors, and

Online Information Review

> perhaps more importantly, for the first time, allowing citizens to look in (Bjola & Cassidy, 2015, p. 10).

Furthermore, digital diplomacy helps bridging offline and online communities (Bjola et. al., 2019) as well as enabling agenda-setting, presence-expansion and conversation-generating (Bjola & Jiang, 2015). Aharony after studying the tweeting activity of three world leaders, concludes that they use Twitter as a channel that allows them to convey their own agenda to the public as what they say stays unfiltered and uncensored by the national and local media (2012, p.606). Some scholars however, observed that interaction with the public was rare and concluded that social media are not tools that enhance deliberative discourses (Kim & Park, 2012) while others observed that those users participating in these interactive processes with politicians are the already established members of the public debate, i.e. popular journalists and bloggers. However, these studies have also noted that the fact that there is a limited number of other users that also participate – many times anonymously – in the public dialogue should not be underestimated as it shows that in the online context public, discussion remains open to alternative participation (Asserhofer & Maireder, 2013; Larsson & Moe, 2012).

Retweeting is an important function of Twitter as it allows the followers of a user to share a post with their own followers. From a flow of information in a network perspective, this means that retweeting carries the message in more places in a network. It helps the initial author-user of the message to engage with more people without the need to directly be connected with them (Boyd et al., 2010, p.1). Apart from the expansion of the network cause that retweeting facilitates however, the very act of retweeting is significant for more than this. Even though scholars do not agree of the actual meaning of retweeting, there are findings that argue that retweeting – with the exception of special groups of users like journalists – indicate the interest, trust and agreement of the retweeter to the message and its originator itself (Metaxas et al., 2015). Such findings become more significant in this current article whenever a user retweets

Online Information Review

the message of the leader of the other community. In other words, retweeting in the case of this study could be considered here as a prominent example of parasocial intergroup contact.

Vicarious and parasocial intergoup contact

The case study of the present article is an example of mediated contact that we see through the lens of the theory of vicarious and parasocial contact. The communication of the Cypriot leaders on Twitter is an example of intergroup mediated contact as it takes place on their official accounts on Twitter that could be followed by anyone at any time. According to Park (2012), mediated contact positively distinguishes from direct contact in terms of intergroup anxiety and that is because it usually takes place in an environment where people feel safe and in control. This is more than valid in the context of Twitter that allows the users to be part of the contact while being in the safety of their personal space. Instances of both vicarious and parasocial contact can be identified during the Twitter communication in the timeframe studied. Vicarious contact takes place whenever the leaders communicate directly with each other on Twitter, or when they share their physical contacts through photos or textual messages on their accounts as the followers of the leaders are watching an ingroup member interacting with an outgroup member (Banas, Bessarabova & Massey, 2020; Harwood, Qadar, & Chen, 2016; Joyce & Harwood, 2014). The contact can be defined as parasocial when the focus of the Twitter user is not on an in-group member having contact with an out-group member but when the viewer creates the feeling of a direct connection to outgroup members via Twitter (Banas, Bessarabova & Massey, 2020; Schiappa, Gregg, & Hewes, 2005). In the case of the current research, any form of interaction between the twitter user and the leader of the other community is an instance of parasocial contact with a prototypical member (leader) of the outgroup.

Online Information Review

One of the social psychological mechanisms at work in mediated intergroup contact seems to be the activation of empathy (Zillman, 1994) which is a key variable in reducing prejudice. The Banas et al. (2020) meta-analysis suggests that both vicarious and parasocial contact have Identical effects on prejudice reduction (both r = −.26). However, they suggest that this does not necessarily mean that the same processes underlie those effects, although the fact that parasocial and vicarious contact can happen simultaneously in mediated contexts (Ortiz & Harwood, 2007) makes disentangling them challenging.

In the case of the leaders' tweeting there is also an additional social psychological variable that comes into play and enhances the potentially beneficial effects of contact which is category salience (i.e., the awareness of a contact person's group membership) which was found to be a key moderator of contact effects (Brown & Hewstone, 2005), Paolini et al. (2010). Leaders are typical or representatives of the groups and in that sense generalisation from the specific encounter with the leader to the whole outgroup is facilitated.

In the case a Twitter user (either GC or TC) witnessing their leaders interacting with each other on Twitter is thus a prime example of Vicarious Mediated Contact (VMC). This can be positive or negative. In the period we examine we mostly observe positive contact of that kind since this was the "honeymoon period" of the leaders (April 2015-October 2016), 1 year and 6 months. Furthermore, the fact that they are leaders in the case of VMC the element of identification with the Ingroup member (especially party supporters of the right-wing persuasion in the case of GCs) could further enhance the positive effects of prejudice reduction (see Harwood et. al., 2016). This also connects to the "two-step flow of communication" hypothesis elaborated by Katz (1957) as it highlights the way opinion leaders "bring the group into touch with this relevant part of its environment through whatever media are appropriate" (p.77).

Online Information Review

Finally, although, there is no research that measures the Cypriots' engagement with the leaders' tweets specifically, a study curating the algorithmic and users' civic attitudes concluded that is online-civic participation is preferred among the GC youth in contrast to the offline one, as it offers low-cost, flexible and effortless engagement (Papa & Photiadis, 2021).

Leadership for an intergroup relational identity

Social identity is usually developed through the process of identification with one's ingroups' behavioural pattern and norms. This identification however most of the times requires some sort of rejection or exclusion of other behavioural patterns and norms that outgroup members have. It imposes some sort of juxtaposition between 'me' – who one is – and 'the other' – who is not. In other words in order for one to feel socially identified with one or more groups s/he needs to ostracise others. Therefore, when intergroup communication is in place the members of each group usually adopt a protective attitude towards their distinct identity (Hogg 2015, p.188) and when they feel that its identity is threatened their behaviour turns competitive or even aggressive. Leaders are important both in the process of identification and in the process of intergroup contact because they constitute a prototypical member of one's group, "the most significant and reliable source of information about that identity" (Hogg, 2015, p.187). Thus, a conflictual intergroup contact could be overcome as Hogg suggests through an effective leadership that would promote (a) "a nonzero-sum superordinate [intergroup] relationship [and] cooperative interaction and (b) the groups have a prolonged, actual, observed or imagined contact with one another that is pleasant and cooperative" (2015, p.188-189). Leaders could embody this through the development of an *intergroup relational identity* (Hogg et al., 2012) which makes the relationship of the group with an outgroup part of the group's identity (Hogg 2015, p.189). Through an intergroup relational identity, the members of the groups participating

Online Information Review

in intergroup contact do not feel that their identity is threatened to lose its distinctiveness or uniqueness because they have an extended sense of self which includes the relationship with this particular other group (Hogg 2015, p.190).

Furthermore, Hogg highlights several strategies that are required for successfully building this intergroup relational identity. These strategies are significant for the unfolding of the argument of this article conveying that the Cypriot leaders' tweeting activity during the period examined, could effectively provide a conducive environment to the Cyprus peace process that is why it is important to list them below.

The first strategy is a *rhetoric* that illustrates in pragmatic and imaginary ways the message that the whole is significantly greater than the parts; second, a *boundary spanning* that will be exemplified by behaviour that strongly promotes strong links and interaction with outgroup members; third, *boundary-spanning leadership coalitions* undertaken through the collaboration of the leaders of different groups themselves; fourth, *external leadership appointments* and *transference of intergroup relational identity* that will be embodied by the projection of already established relationship with an outgroup member aiming in developing new ones (Hogg 2015, pp.193-199).

In this article, we consider the parasocial and vicarious intergroup contact that the two Cypriot leaders perform through their tweeting activity during the timeframe examined, as attempts of building an intergroup relational identity for the Cypriots of both communities. That is why when examining their tweeting activity we will looking for leadership following the above strategies. Given this reasoning this article examineshow exactly was the "honeymoon period" of the Akinci-Anastasiades leadership, that according to other research evidence[1] played a positive role in reducing prejudice levels in both communities, manifested in Twitter use and

[1] https://infogram.com/prejudice-levels-of-gcs-towards-tcs-1hzj4o3y9kny34p?live

Online Information Review

what is the relationship of this practice with the relevant social psychological theories discusses earlier?

Conflict and Hope in Cyprus

Antagonistic nationalism between the largest communities in Cyprus, known today as GCs and TCs persisted despite the island's proclamation as an independent state in 1960, leading to conflict that peaked in 1963-1968 with extremists of both communities. A coup organised in 1974 against the elected president, Makarios, led to the invasion of the island by Turkey supposedly to protect and restore the rights of the TCs. Since then, the GCs live in the Republic of Cyprus (RoC) controlled south, and the TCs in the northern part of the island under the administration of the 'Turkish Republic of Northern Cyprus' (TRNC), recognised internationally only by Turkey. After 2003, physical contact between GCs and TCs is possible, under specific measurements, however bicommunal contact is until now rather stigmatised than normalised.

Regardless of the numerous unsuccessful attempts, the Cypriots of both communities remain hopeful of a solution. According to Leshem (2017), hope is composed by two discrete components, desire and expectation and these components should be measured separately especially when one examines hope in societies in conflict (Psaltis et al., 2021). In Cyprus' case, the discourse of hope for a solution undoubtably dominates the public sphere(s) as is being produced and well established by different social institutions and means. This discourse however is mostly being expressed as a wish for a solution and not as an expectation often representing something abstract and impossible. This became evident with the opening of the crossing points in 2003 a totally unexpected measure for the GCs, despite the fact that their wish for solution and the desire to move freely across Cyprus was dominant throughout the years of separation. The realisation of what the GCs desired was a shocking experience because

Online Information Review

both the media and the political elites produced and maintained a discourse of hope which constructed the meaning of an abstract wish and not as a feasible expectation (Karayianni, 2017).

Methodological Note

The leaders' tweets for the timeframe 30 April 2015 – 31 October 2016 have been downloaded using the package rtweet in R studio.

The data have been analysed in terms of their characteristics. Specifically, a descriptive analysis has been conducted to identify the features of the data collected.

Because the interest of the particular research was only about the tweets related to the Cyprus problem, the total number of 1371 tweets produced by the leaders during the timeframe examined, have been read by the researchers and the ones related to the topic of interest have been selected. This resulted to a number of 668 tweets that they were then read again in an inducive approach as there were not a priori themes in a coding frame but rather the coding of data itself generated the main thematical categories and its subcategories. In the case of the GC leader, five main themes have been identified while in the TC leader's case the coding resulted to six main themes.

A thematic analysis conducted by the authors, generated thirteen subcategories (Table II) contained within those main themes identified. The aim of this analysis was to further understand how themes has been constructed within the leaders' tweets. Thematic analysis has been chosen because of the flexibility it offers to the researcher as a method of analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2006, p.78) and because it allows organising data corpus into patterns. Categorizing data into thematical patterns helped understanding and comparing the themes for which in the two leaders' twitter stream and thereafter to proceed with a discourse analysis to identify the meaning pursued in leaders' tweets included in the themes. The categorization involved a

Online Information Review

rigorously and systematic and reviewing by the authors in order to ensure reliability. Moreover, specific analytical categories were used in the discourse analysis: the language(s) selected to be used by the leader (Greek, Turkish, English), the emotive language included in the tweets, the actors as conveyed by the discourse and the use of media (images, video) in the tweets.

In the analysis we were also looking for evidence of parasocial and vicarious contact in the leaders' Twitter stream and discourses that constructed an intergroup relational identity (Hogg 2015) for the Cypriots of the two communities that is why there has been a special focus on the examination of their most retweeted messages and their characteristics.

Findings and Analysis

Table I presents some descriptive details of the leaders' Twitter accounts. According to the metrics Anastasiades had more than double the number of Akinci's followers, during that period. Although the number of friends, i.e. the number of people each leader was following is smaller than the one of their followers in both cases, Akinci appears to follow a larger number of users than Anastasiades.

The examination of the leaders' Twitter stream shows that more than half of the tweets (N=437) that Akinci has produced within this timeframe was related to the Cyprus problem or the other community while in the case of Anastasiades, the percentage of the Cyprus problem related tweets has been limited to the 36% (N=246).

As expected each leader tweeted mostly in his native language, i.e. Greek for Anastasiades and Turkish for Akinci, following by a high number of tweets in English and a much smaller number of tweets in the language of the other community.

Online Information Review

[*Table I goes here*]

Tweet themes

The Cyprus problem related tweets of the two leaders have been coded according to their theme. This resulted to the identification of certain themes presented in Table II. In Anastasiades' case, five main themes have been observed while in Akinci's case apart from these same five themes, the coding process revealed one more. According to the metrics of Table II, the most commonly found theme (50.64%) in Anastasiades' tweets is Reporting Contacts while the same theme takes the second place (36.15%) in Akinci's tweets, following with a small difference the Expressing Feelings/Intentions which is the top theme (37.75%) in Akinci's tweets. The Expressing Feelings/Intentions theme appears to be the second larger (19.48%) found theme in Anastasiades' tweets but with quite a large difference from the first one while in the theme Announcing upcoming events is the third most found theme in both leaders tweets. The last common found theme in their tweets is the Sending Wishes one and finally in Akinci's tweet an extra theme on Highlighting issues appears with a small percentage (1.83%). The majority of these themes have been broken down into smaller subcategories that are described separately for each community leader below.

[*Table II goes here*]

The leaders' tweets constitute the outmost example of their communication with the public as in comparison to all other media they might also have control of, their official social media accounts are the ones that represent themselves, the prototypical members of their community. Furthermore, what leaders say and do is significant for intergroup contact because "leaders not only set an attitude and behavioral agenda for a group but also convey information about social identity" (Hogg 2015, p.187).

Online Information Review

Reporting contacts

Scrutinizing the tweets of the *Reporting Contacts* theme gives us more indications about the meaning each leader was trying to communicate.

The fact that Anastasiades mostly reported how he discussed the Cyprus problem during his contacts with international officials illustrates Anastasiades' attempt to enhance the discourse of the Cyprus problem as an issue that the international community cares about. In the tweet that follows Anastasiades produces the meaning that important international powers as the EU or US not only know, but also care about the Cyprus problem and most importantly about the GC side's efforts to find a solution. Meanwhile, this kind of tweets constitute reminders about the recognised status of the RoC because only an equally international recognised country could have such contacts.

> "I had the opportunity to brief @JunckerEU on the latest developments in the negotiations for a settlement of the #Cyprus Problem".
>
> (Anastasiades, 16 July 2015)

Akinci tweeted to report mostly something related to the contacts he had with Anastasiades, either on the context of negotiations or in a social context. Some other common subcategories that appeared within this theme were that of reporting contacts with officials of other countries and that of reporting contacts with UN officials. Other tweets within this theme have been posted by Akinci in order to report contacts and related activities with politicians/organisations/bodies while a few others report contacts with EU officials and contacts with Turkish officials.

Online Information Review

Similarly, the discourse of informing and gaining the support of the international community has been developed by Akinci's tweets under this theme. In the following tweet Akinci attempts to construct two meanings: 1. That despite the unrecognised international status of the TRNC[2], the TC community's efforts for solution are not invisible but supported by significant powers in the international community and 2. that the solution to the Cyprus problem will come through EU and this will offer them the European identity that they desire.

> "The British Foreign Secretary @PHammondMp just called me and reiterated his support for the negotiations for the settlement of the Cyprus problem".

(Akinci, 6 June 2016)

The lower number of tweets by Akinci that report contact with Turkish officials in comparison to Anastasiades' tweets that communicate contact with Greek officials is an indication for his attempt to promote a TC identity that is detached from Turkey This meaning is being constructed in tweets with discourse that describe the contact with the Turkish official as contact among equal parts.

> "Received Turkish FM @MevlutCavusoglu. Had a very constructive exchange of opinion on #CyprusProblem & #cooperation".

(Akinci, 26 November 2015)

Moreover, the leaders reported largely their in-between contacts both in the context of negotiations as well as in social context. They communicated information about the environment in which the talks are taking place describing most of the times a positive ambience like "[the meeting was] long but in a friendly atmosphere", "constructive meeting" "It has been a very fruitful meeting", or by sharing media that reflected the atmosphere of the information shared. These tweets constitute (a) examples of vicarious contact as each

Online Information Review

community sees their leader to communicate with the outgroup leader and (b) the leaders' attempt to develop an intergroup relational identity since they appear in both the formal negotiations context and in more casual contexts to apply what Hogg calls as strategy of "boundary-spanning leadership coalition" (2015, p.195). Such an example are tweets like the ones below, in which Akinci shares with the public details and a photograph (Image 2) of the two leaders' walk in the two sides of the divided Nicosia.

> "It was great to walk (together in Arasta, have coffee & ekmek kadayfi[3] al the historic Buyuk Han then walk through Lidras & Onassagorou".
>
> "We had a good start. Continuing well and concluding well is much more important. We should all work to not cause new disappointments".
>
> "I met Mr. @AnastasiadesCY at the Check Point and we had a walk around Arasta.++"
>
> (Akinci, 23 May 2015)

Sharing Statements.

13.85% of Anastasiades' tweets were about sharing statements related to the ongoing negotiations on the Cyprus problem. Several subcategories have emerged from this theme as Anastasiades tweeted to directly inform the public on the ongoing negotiations process, to share his appearances or other kind of media material he published in local and international media and lastly to share his own or other people's speeches on the Cyprus problem. In Akinci's case, the majority of the statements were related to the negotiations process followed by a subcategory which includes tweets in which he shared media material. The two smallest subcategories emerged from tweets in which Akinci shared (a) speeches he gave on several

[3] Traditional Turkish sweet.

Online Information Review

occasions and (b) third parties' statements. In this theme the leaders shared instantly statements that relate to the negotiations process, speeches they had given on several occasions and their appearances in international or local media. This allows the leaders to inform the public directly, conveying their own agenda while keeping it this way unfiltered and uncensored by the national and local media (Aharony 2012, p.606). Similarly, within the Announcing Upcoming Events theme the leaders tend to inform the public about topics they intend to discuss in their meetings, about activities/events they plan to participate and about political decisions they took. This instantaneity "to describe the drama if events unfolding, being recorded and reported online instantly" (Papacharissi & Oliveira, 2012: 8) engages the interest of the public and creates a unique unfiltered relation the leaders and the public. By sharing this kind of information in their tweets the leaders are not just newsworthy sources but are becoming themselves producers of the news stories content.

Expressing Feelings/Intentions.

This constitutes the second most commonly found theme in the Anastasiades' tweets and the largest (38.2%) found in Akinci's tweets. Within this theme the leaders expressed a variety of feelings in relation to the Cyprus peace process and/or the other community. The largest subcategories identified were that of expressing: (a) warnings and (b) hope/expectation for solution.

For example, when the negotiations restarted after the election of Akinci in 2015 both leaders tweeted to express their feelings of hope. Anastasiades tweeted:

> "I hope that today will be the beginning of a bright future for all Cypriots and for our country @MustafaAkinci_1 @EspenBarthEide #Cyprus".
>
> (Anastasiades, 15 May 2015)

Online Information Review

This discourse of hope for a solution is more intense in the case of the TC leader and differs slightly in terms of the meaning the two are trying to construct. Akinci seems to separate in his tweets what he and his community are wishing for from what he is expecting in terms of a solution. The majority of Anastasiades' tweets in this category express mostly the component of desire and not that of expectation. This is indicated by his use of words that represent the meaning of desire of a rather abstract idea of a better future like in the tweet above. On the contrary, Akinci moves beyond the limits of expressing a wish for reaching a solution to expresses his expectation rather than simply his desire. Most of the times he avoids the use of words like "wish", "hope", "desire" that denote just desire but he rather constructs his discourse in a way that produces the meaning of expectation to achieve his goal, like in the tweet below:

> "The Natural Calendar is 2016 and This Target is the Common Target of All Parties".
>
> (Akinci, 26 September 2016)

Here, Akinci moves the discourse of hope from the abstract meaning of wish for a solution to the one of expectation because he uses "expectation indicators" (Leshem, 2017) such as: a date, the word "target" and the characterisation "the common goal".

Another subcategory within this theme is that of *Warnings*. Although both leaders made tweets that expressed some kind of warning, their recipient differs. The majority of Anastasiades warning tweets have as receivers either specific circles within the GC community that act in ways that are harmful to the peace process or to Turkey that acts in ways that are not acceptable. The tweet that follows is a warning to those in the GC community who acted violently to TCs in certain incidents.

> "The state is not going to tolerate behaviors by people who, by invoking pseudo-patriotism, aim to divide our country".
>
> (Anastasiades, 16 November 2015, originally in Greek)

Online Information Review

Similarly, Anastasiades sends a warning to circles of the GC political elite when he tweets:

> "Let the parties take into account the costs they may incur during the dialogue with unfounded allegations".

(Anastasiades, 31 August 2016, originally in Greek)

In both examples, Anastasiades condemns GCs' behavior towards the TCs, setting as the prototypical member of the GC community the "attitudinal and behavioral agenda" (Hogg 2015, p.187) for his group.

The warnings that Akinci is expressing through his tweets have as a receiver mainly the GC community. In most of his tweets he makes the target of the warning explicit. For example:

> "If the Greek Cypriot side internalizes that the Turkish Cypriot people have as much say in these lands as they do, a solution is possible in 2016".

(Akinci, 26 September 2016, originally in Turkish)

Through this kind of tweets, he constructs the meaning of a solution that will ensure and secure equal power sharing between the two communities. Such a discourse has a similar purpose to what Anastasiades is doing with the warnings sent to Turkey and the other side, it offers an affirmation to his ingroup that the only solution discussed is that the group's identity is not threaten.

Sending wishes/Paying Tribute. Twelve tweets of Anastasiades, have been associated to sending wishes on significant days for the two communities.. Again, subcategories have been identified within this theme like sending wishes to the public on religious holidays most of which were associated to religious holidays of the TC community and a subcategory of sending religious on national days some of which again addressed both communities. For Akinci was

Online Information Review

the smallest theme found (2.05%), however, interesting subcategories have been revealed. The largest subcategoryincludes tweets with which Akinci was sending wishes to specific people and/oorganisations in the GC community. In the rest of thetweets he sent wishes to either both communities or to the GC community on the occasion of religious holidays.

The leaders' tweets within this theme often took the form of expressing solidarity. The solidarity is being triggered for two reasons; either because of an incident that occurred to the other community or because of a special day/occasion/celebration that the other community has. Anastasiades for example posted four tweets (two in Greek and two in Turkish) on 16 November 2015 to condemn the attacks against TCs in the south. He also tweeted to send his condolences to the families of the accident victims in Pentadaktylos (in the north) on 29 November 2015. Similarly, Akinci posted six tweets (in Turkish, English and Greek) on 21-22 June 2016 to send a message of sadness about the ecological disaster and his condolences to the family's victim of the Troodos fire (in the south).

It is worth noting the solidarity themed tweets were largely favoured and retweeted by leaders' followers from both communities (a detailed discussion follows).

This discourse can also be identified in the selection of specific words or phrases like "together", "all Cypriots", "Cypriot people", "our country", "we can", "united", "solidarity" all prominent in the tweets. The solidarity discourse constitutes an example of what Hogg calls the "rhetoric strategy" for building an intergroup relational identity as the leaders emphasize the need for intergroup cooperation and stress the linkage between the two communities in an attempt to "transform a largely pragmatic, instrumental, and surface behavioral collaboration into a self-definition" (Hogg 2015, p.194) for the members of their community.

Online Information Review

Announcing Upcoming Events.

Four subcategories emerged from this theme as Anastasiades'tweets announced different types of upcoming activities/events:: (a) the participation of Anastasiades in events, activities both abroad and in Cyprus and (b) upcoming meetings with Akinci, (c) the issues that would be discussed in the upcoming negotiations meeting with Akinci, and (d) political decisions.

Most of Akinci's tweets were related to announcing topics to be discussed, future meetings (social or political) and future events. Two much smaller subcategories included tweets in which Akinci announced political decisions and tweets in which he announced meetings with third party officials. The tweet that follows is indicative of how such information was communicated by the leaders.

> "Today, we decided to conduct two meetings in both June and July with Mr. @AnastasiadesCY. We took steps in a constructive spirit".
>
> (Akinci, 28 May 2015)

The leaders with these tweets shared exclusive information with the public that would otherwise remain in the elite domain or it would reach the public only if the media of the two communities shed light on them.

Retweeting as a parasocial intergroup contact

Particular focus has been given on the retweeting of the leaders' messages as we consider whenever a user retweets a message of the leader of the other community as a prime example of parasocial contact. The ten most retweeted (Table III) related to the Cyprus problem tweets

Online Information Review

of each leader have been examined further in order to identify the ethnicity of the retweeters[4] and other characteristics of these tweets.

The first observation is that only one out of the top ten tweets of each leader does not have retweeters from the other community. In four of Anastasiades' tweets, the TC retweeters are more than everyone else. Also, four of his most retweeted messages were written in both Greek and Turkish, two in Turkish and the other four in English. Three of these tweets include photos and one of them a video. Like photos (Image 1) showing the leaders crossing together the barricade that divides Nicosia in two orshowing him high fiving with a citizen (most probably a TC) during the leaders' stroll in the northern part of Nicosia. The video link that is included in one of his tweets shows the leaders sharing wishes for the New Year in each other's language. The short video starts with a few backstage scenes in which the leaders are laughing together after a few failing attempts of Anastasiades to speak Turkish.

[*Table III goes here*]

Although Akinci's top ten tweets have a slightly lower count of retweets, all of them include GC retweeters. The GC retweeters are more than anyone else in three of these tweets and six of them are written in English, two of them are in Turkish, one tweet in Greek and one is written in both languages. Akinci used media five times in these tweets, one of which is the same video of New Year's wishes that Anastasiades has also shared. In the rest four cases he has shared photos that mostly showed the leaders together in an informal, friendly atmosphere (Image 2.

[Image 1 goes here].

[4] Twitter limits the retweeters' viewing to 30-50 users per tweet so the analysis was based on that number of users only.

Online Information Review

[Image 2 goes here].

The examination of the leaders' top retweeted messages provides evidences of parasocial intergroup contact. We see users of the other community not just following the tweeting activity of the leaders and their in between interaction – which are instances of vicarious contact – but in many occasions we see users interacting with them by amplifying, disseminating and agreeing with their messages through retweeting. Furthermore, the leaders often choose to address the members of the other community directly – and often solely them – by either using their language (or English) or by sending them wishes on their religious holidays. The tweets written in the outgroup's language are perhaps the most obvious examples of parasocial intergroup contact since the leaders are communicating a message directly to the other community. This effort of engagement with the other community becomes more significant in this case as its being done by the prototypical member of the other group, the community leader, making both the parasocial and vicarious contact as well as the message sent highly effective.

Looking at these leaders' attempts for vicarious and parasocial contact through the lens of the intergroup relative identity theory (Hogg, 2015), we conclude that the leaders use the strategies of "boundary spanning" and "boundary-spanning leadership coalition" (ibid). The strategies are applied whenever they share a photo or a video that illustrates their positive in-between interaction and their application is being expanded whenever the leaders are tweeting to address the other community directly. Both strategies provide an imaginary of an extended sense of identity for their ingroup members which includes the collaboration partner (Hogg 2015, p.191), in our scope the other community.

Discussion and Conclusion

Online Information Review

World leaders acknowledge that virtual handshakes on Twitter (Broersma and Graham, 2015) constitute a necessary way of mediating politics in the hybrid media landscape (Chadwick, 2013) as it can help them win or lose elections (Gainous and Wagner, 2014). This was the first time that Cypriot leaders have used Twitter to share information about the Cyprus problem, to address the other community or to communicate publicly with each other. The analysis of the leaders' tweets illustrated how the leaders during that specific timeframe examined, made peace efforts an on-going news story becoming themselves a bridge of contact between the two communities. Instantaneity, that characterises the Twitter in combination with the fact that the information was produced by the most official source – the GC and TC leaders – offered the public stories that not only they aligned "with many of the dominant news values relevance, proximity, […] drama and action" (Papacharissi & Oliveira, 2012) but also information that did not need to be fact-checked. This is particularly important in Cyprus where the public sphere has been segregated since the separation of the two communities. The leaders have often used their tweets to address both communities together or even only the other community by using the other community's language or English as a common language. Such occasions are extremely rare in the public sphere that is facilitated by the media of the island. This study shows though, that digital diplomacy is also useful in conflict-affected societies for contributing to the development of a conducive environment to any on-going peace efforts. The findings indicate that whenever the Cypriot leaders tweeted about the Cyprus problem they were setting up a pro-peace digital agenda (Bjola et al. 2019; Aharony, 2012), choosing themes and constructing discourses that brought the two communities together in the online domain though vicarious and parasocial intergroup contact and that consequently developed an intergroup relational identity (Hogg, 2015) among the two rival sides, something which is not possible within the segregated public sphere of Cyprus. This also underlines that is not enough to examine political, media and cultural environments to understand intergroup contact in conflict-

Online Information Review

affected societies. Digital diplomacy and the way that intergroup contact is achieved through it needs to be taken into consideration. The study also demonstrated that, at least during the specific timeframe examined, the two community leaders – who were the protagonists of the peace negotiations – were supportive towards a solution to the Cyprus problem and through their Twitter accounts contributed in building a conducive environment to the peace process despite any negative voices that dominated the media landscapes of the two communities.

This research has also confirmed that "going digital the once secretive and exclusive domain of the elite [becomes public] allowing citizens to look in (Bjola & Cassidy, 2015, p. 10). The two community leaders have constantly tweeted to report their in-between meetings, to share exclusive details about what they have discussed between them behind closed doors and to announce relevant upcoming events or meetings. Moreover, Twitter has offered a medium to the leaders for expressing solidarity towards the other community in an instant and in many occasions in a personalised way.

Research shows that retweeting indicates the interest, trust and agreement of the retweeter with the message and its originator (Metaxas et al. 2015) thus, the retweeting of leader's tweets by users of the other community constitute intergroup contact that is defined by positive feelings. This highlights again that the affordances of the social media constitute important features for intergroup communication in a segregated public sphere like the Cypriot one.

The main contributions of this article are (a) that it inserts into the discussion of conflict transformation the role of communication through social media,(b) that social media can be more than just tools of diplomacy in the hands of politicians but they could become tools for building what Hogg (2015) defines as an intergroup relational identity, a necessary social

Online Information Review

identity for effective intergroup contact and (c) the practical application that the results offer as they could have an impact on the Cypriot community leaders' (and their consultants) regarding their behaviour on social media especially in periods of intensive negotiations. This article showed that in areas of frozen but yet unresolved conflicts, Twitter is a necessary tool for mediating politics in the hybrid media system (Chadwick, 2015) as it provides the leaders of the rival sides ways for achieving both vicarious and parasocial intergroup contact. Furthermore, when the themes and discourses developed by the leaders' tweets are characterised by positive emotions it means that the intergroup vicarious and parasocial contact takes place in a positive ambience that is conducive to the peace efforts.

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Online Information Review

Table I. Descriptive details of the leaders Twitter account

	Nicos Anastasiades	**Mustafa Akinci**
Followers	103665	41283
Friends	171	385
Tweets Related to the Cyprus Problem	246	437
Tweets in Greek	373	10
Tweets in Turkish	6	629
Tweets in English	245	159

Online Information Review

Table II. Themes identified in the leaders' tweets that are related to the Cyprus problem

	Nicos Anastasiades		Mustafa Akinci	
	Number of Tweets	**%**	**Number of Tweets**	**%**
Reporting Contacts	119	51.51	137	31.35
Sharing Statements	32	13.85	42	9.61
Sending Wishes	12	5.19	9	2.05
Expressing Feelings/ Intentions	47	20.34	167	38.2
Announcing upcoming events	17	7.35	44	10.06
Highlighting issues			14	3.20

Online Information Review

Table III. Ten most retweeted tweets of each leader

GC leader					
Tweet	**Date**	**Retweet Count**	**TC Count**	**Retweeters**	**Media**	**Language**
Happy Bayram (translation in English of the original 'Kurban Bayraminizi en icten dileklerimle kutlarim. Χρόνια Πολλά!')	24 September 2015	172	16	-	Turkish & Greek
Divided by time united by hope (translation in English of the original 'Μας χωρίζει ο χρόνος, μας ενώνει η ελπίδα - Zamanla Bolunduk, Umutla Birlestik #UnitedByHope https://t.co/H3ifCinwZD')	30 October 2016	168	9	Photo	Greek & Turkish
The Rep of #Cyprus does not intend to consent to the opening of any Chapters if #Turkey does not fulfill its obligations	15 March 2016	117	0	-	English

Online Information Review

Μαζί διαμορφώνουμε το μέλλον @MustafaAkinci_1 Together we create the future #Cyprus http://t.co/QtqU2o3TyM http://t.co/pIXdQz1eDe	23 May 2015	117	11	Photo	Greek & English
The behavior of unintelligent persons towards our Turkish Cypriot citizens is unacceptable and deserves condemnation. I express my deep sadness (translation in English of the original Akılsız kişilerin Kıbrıslı Türk vatandaşlarımıza karşı davranış kabul edilemez ve kınamayı hak eder. Derin üzüntümü ifade ederim).	16 November 2015	104	20	-	Turkish
I hope that the conditions for a substantive dialogue will be created, which will lead to the reunification of our country #UnitedCyprus	11 May 2015	98	19	-	English
The state does not tolerate such behavior of individuals or groups who want the permanent partition of the island on the	16 November 2015	95	27	-	Turkish

Online Information Review

grounds of so-called patriotism. (translation in English of the original 'Devlet sözde vatanseverlik gerekçesiyle adanın kalıcı bölünmesini isteyen bireylerin veya grupların bu tür davranışlarına tahammül etmez')					
Wishes of friendship and unity (translation in English of the original 'Ευχές φιλίας και ενότητας. Χρόνια πολλά! Mutlu Yillar')	24 December 2015	95	5	video	Greek & Turkish
We ought to deliver peace and prosperity @MustafaAkinci_1 #ReUnited #Cyprus http://t.co/RcqxrF3WLO	23 May 2015	92	5	Photo	English
I hope that today will be the beginning of a bright future for all Cypriots and for our country @MustafaAkinci_1 @EspenBarthEide #Cyprus	15 May 2015	88	2	-	English

Online Information Review

TC leader

Tweet	Date	Retweet Count	GC Retweeters Count	Media	Language
I want to send a message of optimism for finding a fair and sustainable solution to the Cyprus problem. Happy Resurrection, Happy Easter! (translation in English of the original 'Θέλω να απευθύνω μήνυμα αισιοδοξίας για εξεύρεση δίκαιης και βιώσιμης λύσης στο Κυπριακό. Καλή Ανάσταση, καλό Πάσχα!')	30 April 2016	116	13	Photo	Greek
More than being Muslim or Christian, first we need to be human.	8 September 2015	112	18	-	English
Tonight, we came together with Mr. @AnastasiadesCY, it was a positive meeting, it was a good beginning.	11 May 2015	105	20	-	English

Online Information Review

Tonight, we came together with Mr. @AnastasiadesCY, it was a positive meeting, it was a good beginning. (translation in English of the original 'Sn. @AnastasiadesCY ile bu akşam bir araya geldik. Olumlu bir görüşme ve iyi bir başlangıç yaptığımızı düşünüyorum')	11 May 2015	62	5	-	Turkish
Today, I met Mr. @AnastasiadesCY at the Check Point and we had a walk around Arasta. ++ http://t.co/WDZcQ08CGP	23 May 2015	59	8	Photo	English
Had fruitful mtng w/@JunckerEU Stressed the need to prepare #TurkishCypriots to the #EU along w/ #Cyprus peace talks http://t.co/VWmuewbIlS	30 June 2015	58	9	Photo	English
In Switzerland on 7-11 Nov our goal will be to solve #CyProb in 2016. Will discuss territory & all other outstanding issues interdependently	26 October 2016	57	9	-	English

Online Information Review

We are on the 38th floor of UN Headquarters for the tripartite summit. Our goal is solution (translation in English of the original "Üçlü zirve için BM Genel Merkezi 38'inci kattayız. Hedefimiz çözüm. https://t.co/HklVgFFxK0")	25 September 2016	49	3	Photo	Turkish
We watched a play with @AnastasiadesCY and both Turkish and Greek Cypriot friends in Limassol. http://t.co/ilLHWT9xSa	8 June 2015	47	11	Photo	English
Friendship and peace message for the New year. Merry Christmas (translation in English of the original 'Yeni yıl için dostluk ve barış mesajı. Καλά Χριστούγεννα...')	24 December 2015	46	10	Video	Turkish & Greek

Online Information Review

Online Information Review

Image 1

722x722mm (72 x 72 DPI)

Image 2

72x72mm (72 x 72 DPI)